business'.[59] The cotton textile industry of Ahmedabad in the late 19th century was started by one such Brahmin, Ranchhodlal Chhotalal, after which the traditional Vaish–Jain trading communities such as the Sarabhais and Lalbhais entered the fray.[60]

The Gujaratis' love for business transcended linguistic boundaries through mercantile and entrepreneurial migration. It has been so widespread that it is difficult to single out a period or event, or even a destination, as the initial wave of migration. The first Gujarati migrations are usually associated with the Arabian Sea, extending downwards along the coast of Africa and the Indian Ocean, similar to Chettiar migration along the Bay of Bengal.

Apart from these, another migration stream has branched out within the subcontinent over the past three centuries. More recently, in the 20th century, Europe and the US have drawn in hundreds of thousands of enterprising Gujaratis. These three broad migration waves were often interconnected.

The Gujarati Jains were arguably the first movers. They traded with Arab merchants in the Indian Ocean during the Solanki period between the 10th and 13th centuries. Later, they received preferential treatment in Portuguese-occupied port towns in East Africa in the 16th and 17th centuries.[61] European travellers clearly marked the presence of Gujaratis in Muscat and Zanzibar by noting their lifestyles of strict vegetarianism and effort to preserve all life forms, including insects.[62] Like the Marwaris, their march within India accelerated in the 19th century with Bombay emerging as the key destination for the cotton and trading businesses. According to one account from the 1930s, Jains ran over 40 per cent of the grocery and provision shops in Bombay even though they comprised less than 2 per cent of the population.[63] Unlike the Marwaris, however, they also reached important textile hubs in south India, especially those around Coimbatore. The Jains usually migrated from the principal urban centres in Gujarat, such as Ahmedabad and Surat, to form new businesses whereas some migrated from other places. The Jains of Palanpur, for instance, were well versed with the jewellery business and their migration, noted later in this chapter,